Note-Taking Strategies

Pick a format that fits the class. The skills on the back make any format work.

01 Pick a format *Match it to how the class is taught*



Cornell

Notes on the right, cue questions on the left, a summary at the bottom.

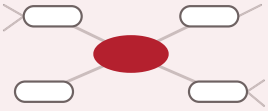
BEST FOR
Lectures you'll study from



Outline

Main ideas at the margin, details indented under them.

BEST FOR
Organized lectures and readings



Mind map

Topic in the center, branches for big ideas and details.

BEST FOR
Big topics with lots of connections



Chart

Things you're comparing down the side, categories across the top.

BEST FOR
Comparing two or more things



Flowchart

A box for each step or cause, with arrows showing what leads to what.

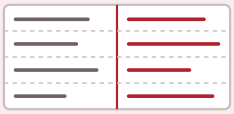
BEST FOR
Processes, cause and effect



Boxing

Each topic gets its own box, so related ideas stay together.

BEST FOR
Units with a few separate topics



Problem and why

The work on the left, why each step happens on the right.

BEST FOR
Math and science problems

HELPFUL TIP

Mix and match.

Formats aren't all or nothing. Drop a chart or flowchart into your notes when the lesson calls for it.

The best format is the one you'll actually study from.

02 Set up your system *So you can find your notes when you need them*

One home per class. A binder section, a notebook, or a digital folder for each class. Notes never float loose.

Keep a table of contents. The first page lists the date, topic, and page number for each set of notes.

Head every page. Class, date, and topic at the top, so you can find any day in seconds.

Name files the same way. Digital notes follow one pattern every time, like "Bio U3 Cell Energy Oct 26."

Note-Taking Strategies

03 During class *Get down what matters*

Listen for signals. Teachers flag what matters by repeating it, writing it on the board, or saying it's important. Star those parts.

TRY IT
Hear "the main reason was"? Star what comes next.

Use your own words. Rephrase as you go so you're thinking while you write. Copy exact wording only for definitions and formulas.

TRY IT
"Plants turn light, water, and CO_2 into sugar."

Leave space. Skip a line between ideas and leave room under examples. You'll fill it in when you review.

TRY IT
Leave a gap after each heading for examples.

Mark what's confusing. Put a ? next to anything you don't get. Ask about it after class or at the start of the next one.

TRY IT
"? why does the sign flip here" in the margin.

Use shorthand. Make up your own if you like. Just use the same symbols every time.

w/	with	w/o	without	b/c	because	→	leads to	∴	therefore
↑	increases	↓	decreases	≈	about	ex	example	def	definition

04 After class *Turn notes into something you can study*

Review within a day. Spend 5 to 10 minutes the same day filling the spaces you left and answering any ? you can.

TRY IT
After school, finish the example you only half copied.

Turn notes into questions. Write questions in the margin or the Cornell cue column. Later, cover your notes and answer them.

TRY IT
"What are the three types of rock?"

Summarize it. At the bottom of the page, write two or three sentences on the big idea in your own words.

TRY IT
"Today was about how cells get energy."

Fill the gaps. Check your notes against the slides, the textbook, or a classmate. Add what you missed in a different color.

TRY IT
Missed two steps of an example? Add them in red.